

Tony Umeh
John Paul Ugar

PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE:

Fundamental Concerns

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Benjamin Ikechukwu Ewelu

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CHAPTER 5

PROBLEM OF LANGUAGE AND THOUGHT

The problem of the relation between language and thought is an age old problem. This problem can be thus stated:

1. Are thinking and speech always interrelated or is it possible to have thinking without speech and speech without thinking?
2. If thinking and speech are not identical, being only in some way related to each other, what is the role of speech in the thought process?¹

The problem of language and thought is that of determining the relationship between them. It is the problem of finding out the role language plays in thought and vice versa. There is also the question whether thought and language exist independently of each other or whether each needs the other in order to exist. Language is generally believed to have some influence on thought and thought on language. While some thinkers hold that language is indispensable in thought, others maintain that man does not need language in order to think. The problem of thought and language has received the greatest attention in the 20th century. It has become an interdisciplinary problem which touches not only philosophy and psychology, but also linguistics, cognitive sciences, computer sciences etc. While philosophers and others investigate the problem speculatively, the experimental scientists think it better to face it experimentally. This book concerns itself with the speculative approach.

¹ A. N. Sokolov, *Inner Speech and Thought*, tr. by G. T. Onischenko. (New York-London: Plenum Press, 1972), p. 11.

Views on the Problem of Language and Thought

Among the views expressed by those involved in the debate about the interrelationship between language and thought, three views are distinguishable. In the first place, there is the **monistic view**, the view that language and thought are but one and the same mental faculty/activity. Secondly, there is the **dualistic view** which is the opposite extreme position to the monistic view. This is the view that language and thought are not only different activities/faculties, but they are separate from and independent of each other.² Finally, there are those who hold the moderate view (the **symbiotic view**), those who perceive language and thought as different activities/faculties but at the same time consider them as inseparable from each other in the sense that one needs the other for its being and function.

1. The Monistic/Reductionist View

The proponents of monistic view try to identify language and thought as one and the same faculty. Thought in this view is reduced to language, to an inner silent speech. The ancient Greeks, for instance, use the same term *λογος* (*logos*) to refer both to language and thought. The term *logos* signifies both word (speech, language, statement, discussion, discourse) and thought (concept, reason, sense, science). Every scientific study or discourse about the nature and laws of the universe is called *logos*. Although the use of the term *logos* is diverse and has undergone some changes, this term always retains the unity (if not identity) of language and thought. *Logos* (philosophy) is used in contrast to *mythos* (myth), for in *logos* word and reason go together. *Logos* is science, it is study. On this type of usage

² Confer G. Révész, "Denken und Spechen." *Acta Psychologica*, 10 (1954), pp. 3 - 6. Révész exposes how the monistic view and the dualistic view have formed the two major camps in the age old debate on the interrelationship between language and thought.

of the term *logos* among the ancient Greeks Thomas Hobbes writes:

The Greeks have but one word, λογος, for both *speech* and *reason*; not that they thought there was no speech without reason, but no reasoning without speech.³

The use of the term *logos* among the Greeks, therefore, implies that for them there is a very narrow relationship between language and thought. This relationship is so narrow for them that they almost identify the two mental activities. If the position of Hobbes on the use of *logos* among the Greeks is correct (and I think it is), it means then that for the Greeks thought is not possible without language and vice versa. In short, the two are one and the same thing.

Plato carries the identity of language and thought to its final conclusion. He describes thinking as a *discussion* which the mind conducts with itself, a discussion in which the mind asks itself questions and answers them, in which the mind asserts and denies. Thinking for Plato is nothing but discussing, only that it is a silent discussion in the mind.⁴ In another dialogue Plato says that thought is "the same thing as speech except that it is the mind's inner silent talking to itself".⁵ In this sense we not only think in language, thinking itself is but internal speech (a *sotto voce*). It is speech minus sound. Even belief, for Plato, is done in language: "when someone believes. . . apparently he says to himself. . ." ⁶ (emphasis mine). We have philosophy only because we have language for "if we were without it

³ T. Hobbes, *Leviathan*, Part One, chapter IV.

⁴ Plato, *Theatetus*, 189e - 190a.

⁵ Plato, *Sophist*, 263e. Cf. also 264a.

⁶ Plato, *Theatetus*, 190a.

[language] we would be without philosophy".⁷ Plato thus reduces thought to language.

The earlier works of Wittgenstein has much inclination towards platonism. In his *Notebook* (1916) he describes thought as a kind of language, a sort of internal silent speech. In the *Notebook* we read:

Now it is becoming clear why I thought that thinking and language were the same. For thinking is a kind of language. For a thought too is, of course, a logical picture of the proposition, and therefore it is just a kind of proposition.⁸

In the *Tractatus*, Wittgenstein describes thought as "a proposition with a sense"⁹ and language as the "totality of propositions"¹⁰. He also equates the limits of a person's world to the limits of his language: "*The limits of my language mean the limits of my world*".¹¹ This is a way of saying that only those things I can speak about are the things I can imagine and think about. In short the "early"¹² Wittgenstein identifies thought with language.

⁷ Plato, *Sophist*, 260a.

⁸L. Wittgenstein, *Note Books 1914 – 1916*, 2nd edition, G. H. von Wright and

G. E. M. Anscombe (eds.), tr. G. E. M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1979), 82.

⁹L. Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, tr. G. E. M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1968, first published in 1953), no. 4.

¹⁰*Ibid.*, no. 4.001

¹¹*Ibid.*, no. 5.6.

¹²The expression "early Wittgenstein" refers to Ludwig Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, which is the first philosophical work by Wittgenstein and which defends the monistic view about the relationship between language and thought. The later work of Wittgenstein *Philosophical Investigations* departs greatly from this view.

The identification of language and thought cannot be correct, for if both were one and the same thing, the question of the relationship between them would not have arisen in the first place. Plato's description of thinking as conversation the soul holds with itself has awakened many reactions among those who are interested in the study of the human cognition and the human language. Many of those in defence of the autonomy of thought have gone to the other extreme of denying any relationship whatsoever between it and language, thus falling into the temptation of the dualism between language and thought.

2. Dualistic and Expressionist View

Dualism here is understood in the sense of dichotomy between language and thought. Dualistic view treats language and thought as completely separated from each other. Its proponents are concerned mainly with the defence of the autonomy and the purity of thought. Most of those who hold this dualistic opinion consider language as serving only as a means of expressing thought when there is a need for doing so. It is in this sense that we are using the term "expressionism" or "expressionist" as the case may be. The thinkers who hold this view include, among others, St. Augustine, Francis Bacon, René Descartes, John Locke, Leibniz, David Hume, and some contemporary thinkers like G. Ryle, Eric Buyssens, Van der Waerden and others.

In defense of the purity of thought

St. Augustine holds that thoughts exist in the mind independently of language and of senses, for they are imprinted there by the Creator himself. Mind which is the house of thoughts is also the source of language. Thought is pure and free from all symbolic and sensual representations. Language is only a means of expressing thought, the role which it is

incapable of accomplishing properly. The content of thought is so profound that even the thinker hardly finds adequate words to express it. Language, in St. Augustine's understanding, depends on thought, and not the other way round. I cannot speak of objects even if they are there before my senses "unless I could see them in my mind's eyes".¹³ Emphasising the independence of thought from language St. Augustine writes: "words may sometimes be spoken in Latin and at other times in Greek, but the principles are neither Greek nor Latin. They are not language at all".¹⁴ Our thoughts are free from all forms of representation and we know them without reference to any material object, but by simply thinking of them inside our minds which is, for St. Augustine, the source of all knowledge. Language, for St. Augustine, plays no role in man's thinking and it is completely separate from thought. The preoccupation of St. Augustine is that of defending the purity of the human thought. It is in thought that man resembles God and not in language. Thought is spiritual and heavenly, while language is mundane. This is in line with the Catholic theology (of which St. Augustine is one of the most renowned foundation members) according to which the soul is incorruptible and divine. To accept that language, or any image of any type or whatever can come from the senses, can have any influence on the human thought is, in St. Augustine's opinion, to play down on the sacredness of the human soul. This dualistic perception of man was rejected by St. Thomas Aquinas who, basing on Aristotle's theory of hylomorphism,¹⁵ proposed the composite

¹³St Augustine, *The Confessions*, Bk. X, 8.

¹⁴*Ibid*, Bk. X, 12.

¹⁵ The term "hylomorphism comes from two Greek words *hyle*, "matter" and *morphe*, "form". According to Aristotle's philosophy, matter and form constitute an inseparable unit. There is no uninformed matter and there is no matterless form. Confer Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, Book XII.

view of man. Man is a composite being, and the whole man (body and soul) is sacred and meant for salvation.

In line with St. Augustine but for reasons different from that of St. Augustine (for scientific rather than religious reasons), Francis Bacon defends the purity of thought. He considers language as one of the sources of the four idols (the idols of the tribe, of the den, of the market place and of the theatre) that beset men's minds and prevent them from reasoning properly and freely. Of the four idols (prejudices) the most troublesome, says Bacon, are those of the market place which are prejudices originating from inadequacies in the nature and use of our language. He explains the idols of the market as:

idols formed by the reciprocal intercourse and society of man with man. . .; for men converse by means of language, but words are formed at will of the generality, and there arises from a bad and inapt formation of words a wonderful obstruction to the mind.¹⁶

He accepts the influence of word (language) on thought. But this influence is only *per accidens* and a negative one: "men imagine that their reason governs words, whilst, in fact words *react upon* the understanding; and this has rendered philosophy and the sciences sophistical and inactive".¹⁷ This is so because, according to him, words are borne out of popular, unscientific and vulgar minds. As such, they lack the precision needed for scientific thinking. It is for this reason that some philosophers of the 20th century attempted to construct a more scientific language (an ideal language), an attempt which culminates in the symbolic logic of Frege, Russell, Quine etc.

¹⁶Francis Bacon, *Novum Organum*, Bk I, 43.

¹⁷*Ibid.*, 59. (emphasis mine, to stress the fact that, for Bacon, the influence of language on thought is only an intrusive influence and not a necessary nor an important influence). Language, as it were, encroaches on thought and disturbs its adequate functioning.

Thoughts (ideas) as entities in the mind

In the works of empiricists Locke and Hume, ideas are described as entities in the mind. Language becomes but just the means of expressing these ideas, and the meaning of words and sentences are the ideas in the mind of the speakers. Ideas, therefore, exist in the mind independently of language.

John Locke presents both broad and narrow conception of the thinking. In its broad conception the term 'thinking' covers the following: sensations, perceptions, memory, imagination, concepts etc. In its narrow conception thinking becomes the operation of the mind with respect to its ideas, where the mind is actively contemplating everything with a certain degree of voluntary attention. Both in its broad and narrow senses the role which Locke assigns to language is that of standing for and expressing thoughts (ideas in the mind). Man uses language "as signs of internal conceptions" and "as marks of ideas within his own mind".²⁰ In this sense language stands for what a person has in mind, the conceptions and ideas of his mind. In all passages where Locke tries to write on the relationship of language and thought he stresses only the expressive function of language: language is merely a means of expressing to others the ideas which one has already in one's mind. Locke's theory of ideas suggests that ideas are formed independently of language. They precede language in order of existence in the sense that man's language is needed to express to others the ideas already there in the mind. While thinking, a person's mind thinks about "the ideas that are there".²¹ Thinking is a subjective activity. Language, on the other hand, is for social purposes, opines Locke. It is because man is a social being that God has endowed him with language as a means of

²⁰ J. Locke, *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. Bk. III, chapter 1, 2.

²¹ *Ibid.*, Bk. II, chapter, 1, 1

communicating with his fellow men.²² Language is needed only when man wants to communicate to others "great variety of thoughts. . . within his breasts, invisible and hidden from others".²³ Given the fact that Locke defends the primacy of ideas, he could not but defend the expressive view about language. "If thoughts are primary", writes Donald Davidson, "a language seems to serve no purpose but to express or convey thoughts."²⁴ Contrary to Locke's, Hobbes is of the view that man is able to live in society because he is capable of language, and not the other way round. The content of man's thought comes from the social language and other social elements he has internalised.

The important question here is: from where, according to Locke, comes the ideas in man's mind? Locke's theory of ideas recognises two sources of ideas in man's mind: sensation and reflection. By reflection we deduce certain general information from the particular concrete sensation we are having. But then, can we reflect on something without language?. To reflect on our ideas means to examine and re-examine them and to raise questions about them and try to provide some answers. Language, therefore is fully involved in the activity called reflection. The thoughts and ideas that are communicated are themselves internally conceived and arranged in and by means of language. While a person is undergoing some sensations he forms some ideas about what he senses by means of language. Where there is no language in operation, the sensation remains a mere feeling from which a person gets no information. To form ideas from the sensation a person is having is to abstract

²² *Ibid.*, chapter 1, 1.

²³ *Ibid.*, Bk. III, chapter 2, 1

²⁴ D. Davidson, "Thought and Talk", in *Readings in Language and Mind*. Ed. by H. Geirsson and M. Losonsky. OxfordUK and Cambridge, MassachusettsUSA: Backwell Publishers, 1996, p. 234.

general information from this particular concrete experience and to compare it with other ideas. Such an abstraction and comparison is possible only by means of language. It is by means of language that one is informed about the sensation he is having. Even if he does not yet have a precise word for a certain sensation he is having, he knows that he is feeling *something*, say in the stomach. To think that I am feeling *something* is already to think in language, even before finding a precise name for this *something*.²⁵

Locke maintains the expressionist position because he considers ideas as entities in the mind. A person expresses these entities when the need arises. Thus, on the question of the meaning of a word, Locke asserts firmly that it consists of the idea in the mind of the speaker of the word in question: "words, in their primary or immediate signification, stand for nothing but *the ideas in the mind of him that uses them*. . . . and the end of speech is, that those sounds, as marks, may make known his ideas to the hearer".²⁶ Words are nothing but careful expressions of ideas we have in mind. In summary, Locke treats language as "subservient to instruction and knowledge"²⁷, as messenger of ideas already there in the mind. This is a dualistic, thus a non-satisfactory, solution to the problem of the relationship between language and thought

The same dualistic view is seen in Leibniz as is clear enough in following passage:

Anyone who has seen a sheep killed has had an idea of that act in his thought, even if he has not deemed it worth his attention and has not given it a name. Why, then,

²⁵L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigation*, paragraphs 261 and 335.

²⁶J. Locke, *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*, chapter 2, 2.

²⁷*Ibid.*, chapter 1, 6.

should we restrict ourselves to names when our concern is with the ideas themselves....²⁸

Leibniz is of the view that thought is possible in the absence of language. What Leibniz does not make clear is how a person gives attention to an experience he has had. To give it such an attention, in my own understanding, is to reflect on it in order to make certain conclusions about it and thus get oneself further informed. It is by means of language that such a giving of attention is possible. Leibniz, however, seems to have failed to see this point.

For Hume, in line with Locke, thoughts (ideas) are entities in the mind and not activities of the mind. Because Hume does not consider thinking as an activity, he fails to notice the role of language in thinking, or in the formation of these ideas. Language for him, therefore, is only a means of expressing and describing the entities in the mind which he calls impressions and ideas.²⁹

J. C. Doig strongly criticises the view that ideas are entities in the mind.³⁰ Such a view leads to epistemological relativism - the doctrine that only the thinker knows what is in his mind, for no other person can have access to ideas in his mind. This view leads also to epistemological solipsism which is the doctrine

²⁸ G. W. Leibniz, *New Essays on Human Understanding*. Op. Cit., p. 301.

²⁹ D. Hume, *Inquiries Concerning Human Understanding*, Section III, 18.

³⁰ Confer J.C. Doig, *In Defense of Cognitive Realism: Cutting the Cartesian Knot*. (Lanham, New York, London: University Press of America, 1987), pp. 273 - 279. Doig is of the opinion that the "entity in the mind" theory is a false theory that has led the human inquiry to no success. As such, it should be denied. On this he writes: "One can remove what is false only by denying its validity. One must cut the Cartesian knot, not untie it, and one does that by denying the possibility of examining ideas, or anything substituted for them. . . .", p. 275.

that only my existence and my ideas can be known for certain. There is, thus, scepticism about the knowledge of the external world and of the other mind. Experience, according to this view, becomes personal to each person. It is private to him in the sense that another person does not have access to it. This view has its origin in Descartes' epistemology, according to which any existence other than my own existence may be just an invention of the *ego*. Following from this, Locke reduces knowledge to "the perception of the connection of an agreement, or disagreement and repugnancy of any of our ideas". This becomes the maxim of solipsism and scepticism championed by Hume. Kant's unknowable "thing-in-itself" is another off-spring of Cartesianism. The same is the case with the sense-data argument. The view that meaning and truth are founded on the idea in the mind has led to other questionable psycho-epistemological theories like Freud's unconscious mind and the 19th century German psychology.³¹

Ryle's denial of the essential role of language in thinking

Among the contemporary philosophers Gilbert Ryle holds a dualistic position on the question of the relationship between language and thought. He considers it a great error to think that thinking by nature needs language, or anything at all. He attributes this error to Plato's erroneous definition of thinking as "the discussion the soul conducts with itself"³². For Ryle, thinking takes place independently of language. His rejection of the indispensability of language in thinking follows from his concept of thought according to which there is no specific element that is common to all activities that the verb "think" covers. There is nothing that is essential for thinking to take

³¹ See the conclusion of this chapter.

³² G. Ryle, "Thinking and language." *op. cit.*, pp. 261 - 262.

place.³³ He, therefore, rejects the opinion that thinking consists of symbols or is "operations with symbols. Such a view, he writes is "false or else highly misleading" for, "there is nothing of which we can say quite generally the 'thinking consists of that'".³⁴ Neither language is, nor symbols nor images are, essential to thinking. Thinking does not need any vehicle in order for it to take place. Thinking can go on without images, without symbols, and without language.³⁵ Thinking can take place without language for "thinking" understood as pondering is nothing but a wandering in the void. According to him, a musician's thought while trying to compose a piece is not in language. Even when he has finished the composition the musician can hum or play the music without necessarily being able to explain the music in words or represent it in musical notes. This example given by Ryle, however, is not a correct example of a thinking without a vehicle. The vehicle in this case is the musical *tone* which a person can listen to in his "mind's ear". It would have been correct if Ryle says that no definite vehicle is indispensable for all forms of thinking than to say that no vehicle whatsoever is indispensable. That *no definite vehicle* is indispensable is not the same as *no vehicle* is indispensable. This is similar to Buyssen's argument (to which I shall come very shortly) that the fact that one can express his thought in many different languages is a proof that thinking is done without language.

³³ Cf. G. Ryle, "A Puzzling Element in The Notion of Thinking." *Proceedings of the British Academy*, 64 (1958). Reprinted in *Collected Papers*, op. cit., pp. 404 - 406. Ryle holds that we cannot "reserve for our thinkings any peculiar concrete stuff, apparatus, or medium, X, such that we can say, 'As no singing without poises, so no thinking without X'". P. 404.

³⁴ G. Ryle, "Thinking and language.", op. cit., p. 263.

³⁵ Cf. G. Ryle, "Thinking and reflecting." In *Collected Papers*, op. cit., 469.

Ryle, however, accepts that there are certain types of thinking that necessarily need language as their vehicle. He points out three of these. (i) In trying to compose a speech or a poem. In this case the thinking is "itself a piece of word-hunting, phrase-concocting, and sentence-mending". (ii) In trying to resolve a slightly complex piece of computation like $\sqrt{998767}$, or $1378937 \div 377$. Here the thinker needs to think by the help of the figures involved. (iii) Finally, some kinds of problems like those of advocates, debaters, and philosophers require thinking in words. These are people whose professions are accomplished by means of words and, as such, they think by means of words.³⁶ These three types of thinking, however, are exceptions to the rule. The rule for Ryle is that thinking does not necessarily need any vehicle - be it in the form of language, images, or symbols - for it to take place. Ryle, therefore, holds a dualist view about the problem we are examining.

Language pluralism, mathematical signs, musical notes and paintings as proofs of the dispensability of language in thinking.

Eric Buyssens in his paper³⁷ defends vehemently the dualistic view with regard to the relationship between language and thought. He sets out to demonstrate that a person does not need language to think. He bases his proof on three points. Firstly, the same words can express different thoughts. In other words, the same propositional attitude can express diverse propositional contents. He illustrates this point with the sentence: "My father is ill." When Buyssens makes this sentence he has the image of an eighty year old fat man with all his physical and other characteristics. He argues that although

³⁶ Cf. G. Ryle, "A puzzling elements in the notion of thinking", *op. cit.*, pp. 394 - 395. See also "Thinking and Language", *op. cit.* p. 262

³⁷ Cf. Eric Buyssens, "Speaking and thinking from the linguistic standpoint." *Acta Psychologica*, 10 (1954), pp. 137 - 164.

others can make the same sentence, none can have the same image (the same thought) he has of his father. When another person says "My father is ill" this other person may be thinking of a fifty-five year old slender man. Each person's idea of "my father" is according to his own father's characteristics and the person's personal conception of his father. This point can be illustrated by another example: "I am thinking about my car." When this sentence is made by different persons, each person thinks about a car peculiar to him. One may be thinking of a small red Opel Corsa, the other about a mighty black BMW, another about an executive white Renault etc. In other words, the psychological states and the propositional contents of the identical sentence made by different subjects are not identical.³⁸ This, according to Buyssens, makes it clear that the same words can express different thoughts, and that, therefore, according to him, thought and language are independent.

The second point is that the same thought can be expressed in different words, what he calls "language pluralism". The fact that one can choose which words to use in expressing his thought proves, in Buyssens' opinion, that thinking is independent of language, (p. 158). "Our mental activities", he writes, "commands language, it is not dependent on it, it does not need the embodiment of language to work." (p. 159). He asserts that "the best argument in favour of the independence of mind [i.e., of thought] is linguistic pluralism", (p. 160).

Thirdly, Buyssens says that language can never express thought completely; it only conveys part of it. That is to say

³⁸ This is the case of "bifurcation" between belief states and belief contents, or between psychological states and propositional contents. On psychological states and propositional contents confer H. Putnam (1975a) "Twin Earth Cases", Kaplan (1977), Fodor (1981), and Pierre Jacob (1984).

that thought is richer and more profound than language. It is this inability of language to express thought well that has "induced scientists to devise a new language", the language of signs like mathematical and logical signs and other signs used by scientists in their respective disciplines. For example, in trying to describe to the workman the type of chair I want him to build for me, "it is impossible to describe my chair by means of words alone, I must resort to a drawing. This is the experimental proof that my mind is sometimes unable to express itself in words, that my mind is richer than language; at such moments I am thinking without any words.", he concludes (p. 160).

These three points of Buyssens are quite interesting. However, they need to be examined more carefully. Buyssens seems to think that mathematical and other signs are not language and that a person who thinks by means of these signs thinks by means of no language: "A mathematician does not think in his mother tongue. This fact shows how easy it is to get rid of linguistic habits", (p. 159). Buyssens seems to ignore the fact that mathematical symbols and the symbols of physicists, astronomers, musicians etc. are constructed from natural languages and that each person who understands these symbols do so only in the natural language he normally speaks. For sure, the mathematician has learned these symbols in the language he speaks and he understands them in the language he understands. The English speaker looking at the following mathematical equation $4 + 18 > 6 \times 3$ reads "Four plus eighteen is greater than six times three"; and the French speaker reads "*Quatre plus dix-huit est plus grand que six fois trois*". It is, therefore, not correct to say that mathematicians do not think in natural languages or that mathematical symbols prove that thought is free from

language. Mathematical symbolism is, anyway, itself a kind of language.

Again to move from the fact that a person can express his thought in different languages to the conclusion that his thought is independent of language is not logically valid. The fact that I can reach Lagos from Onitsha through *different routes* does not imply that I can reach Lagos from Onitsha through *no route*. It implies that I can reach Lagos through *any* of the available routes. *Any* does not imply *none*, it logically means *at least one*. Buyssens seems to think that saying that thinking is dependent on language is to identify it with language, thus he argues that thinking is "some activity that is not language" (p. 160). To say that thinking depends on language implies rather that each is different from the other. If they were identical, the question of their relationship would not have arisen at all. The only relation that Buyssens acknowledges between language and thought is that the latter is communicated by means of the former. Buyssens, anyway, considers language from the linguistic point of view where attention is paid only to the external and social characteristics of language. "For linguist", he writes, "language remains a means of communication." (p.160), "type of social behaviour", (p. 164).

In line with Buyssens and Ryle, another writer Van der Waerden,³⁹ is of the view that mathematical thinking, musical thinking etc. are possible without language. As the title of his paper ("DenkenohneSprache" – Thought without Language) suggests, Van der Waerden tries in his paper to prove the possibility of thinking without language. For him, it is not only

³⁹Cf. B. L. Van der Waerden, "DenkenohneSprache", *Acta Psychologica*, Ibid., pp. 165 - 174.

a possibility, it is a reality. There are different forms of thought in reality without language, he argues. He does not deny the importance of language in thinking nor the fact that thinking is to a great extent influenced by language. His bone of contention is the theory that language is necessary (*notwendig*) for thinking. He asserts that we can think without language because we do think without language. To buttress his point, Van der Waerden exposes five types of thinking, trying to show in each case that such type of thinking is possible without language (*Sprache*).

First, geometrical thinking (*Das geometrische Denken*). In Waerden's opinion one needs three kinds of ideas (*Vorstellungen*) for geometrical thinking: (i) motor-like idea (*motorische Vorstellung*), like the movement of the hand in drawing a curve; (ii) visual idea (*visuelle Vorstellung*), the curve as it stands before the eyes; and (iii) language idea (*sprachliche Vorstellung*), the name of the curve. From this, he argues that much of the thinking has been done before language comes into play. Language, according him, comes in only on the final stage. The curve has come into existence before a person begins to look for what to call it. The person has already had the full clear knowledge of the curve before finding the name: "*Er hat einenvölligklaren Begriff von der Kurve gehabt, bevor er den Namen erfand.*" (p. 166). One does not need the name he has given to the curve in order to think of it later. He can always visualise the curve without the mediation of language and in the same way he can have a full thought of reality without the intervention of the language, (p. 167).

The second type of thinking where language is not necessary, according to Waerden, is logical thinking ("*Das logische Denken*"). Waerden argues that one can also think logically

without words. It is from the experience of the thought process, not of language, that one goes from the premises to the conclusion. He concludes that a person can grasp the logical connection without any word (*"Man kann den logischen Zusammenhang auch ohne Worte andeuten."*), (p. 168). We cannot here but wonder what our author means by a person going from the premises to the conclusion without the intervention of language. One cannot consistently say that discursive (logical) thought is possible without language. It is contradiction in terms.

Third, practical thinking (*"Das praktische Denken"*). The argument here is that a person can accomplish a lot in technical life, for example in the construction and the use of tools, without any need of word. In such a thinking, he argues, names/words play no role in the whole reflection (*"die Namenspielen bei der ganzen Überlegung keine Rolle"*), (p. 169). People invent many things before they look for the name to give them. It is only when everything is ready that the things is given its name (*"wenn alles fertig ist erhält das Ding seinen Namen"*), (*ibid.*). Here I would ask with Wittgenstein: what does the thinking consist in before the name is given to the thing discovered?⁴⁰ Language "is not . . . the final label put upon the finished thought".⁴¹

Fourthly, Van der Waerden considers thinking in formulas (*"Das Denken in Formeln"*) as a form of thinking that is possible without language. The point he makes here is that mathematicians do not think by means of formulas because the thoughts have been there before the formulas were coined.

⁴⁰ L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 335

⁴¹ E. Sapir, *Language: an introduction to the study of speech*. (London. Toronto. Sydney. New York: Granada, 1979 first published 1921), p. 15.

Great Greek mathematicians did not know any formulas, he points out.

Finally he talks of abstract thinking ("Das abstrakte Denken"). Van der Waerden does not contest the fact that thinking functions with ideas (*Vorstellungen*). He, however, poses the question: but must the symbols here be words? ("abermüssen die Symbole gerade Worte sein?" p. 170). For him all symbols are not verbal. Abstract thinking can go on without verbal symbols. Although abstract thinking is influenced by language, it is possible without language, he concludes.

Summarising, he says that the above five types of thinking are "all independent from language" (p. 173). Thought is inborn (innate) in man, but language is learnt, he says: "thinking is inborn, language we have learnt", (p. 173). Language is dependent on thought while thought remains independent from language (*ibid.*). "Thinking is always the first, language second." (*ibid.*). To the question whether language is indispensable to thought, Van der Waerden's answer reads: "No. Thinking without language is possible, not only practical, technical, and geometrical thought, but also highest level of abstract thinking." (p. 171).

It is important to note that Van der Waerden never denies the important role language plays in thinking and that is why he writes: "We think but also with the help of language: we make use of verbal ideas (*Wortvorstellungen*) as comfortable assistance for knowledge" (*Begriffen*). (p. 171). He agrees that it is a correct psychological remark to say that a person thinks almost always in words, but words are dispensable (*entbehrlich*) in thinking. Van der Waerden's five arguments are quite vivid and brilliant. The important point, however, is to understand what he actually means by the term "*Sprache*" (language). If by that he understands only spoken or written

words, of course, thinking sometimes goes before words are spoken or written and at other times the two go on simultaneously. If, however, language is understood in its broad sense as a means by which a person is informed, a means which includes words, writings, signs, symbols, gestures etc., then language is fully involved in all the five types of thinking as Van der Waerden describes them.

The main reason for the dualistic and expressionist attitude to the relationship between language and thought is that of conceiving thought as something (entity) already-made in the mind (St. Augustine, Descartes), or as something which can be "impressed" on the mind (Hume). St. Augustine's dichotomistic attitude towards body and soul, with the soul and its thought in the pure world of their own and the body and its language in this world of decay, is quite incorrect. It is not possible to say that ideas are formed through reflections and at the same time to say that language has no role to play in the formation of ideas (Locke). Reflection by its very nature is done by means of language. Francis Bacon's view is an exaggerated conception of the purity and adequacy of scientific thought which language unfortunately encroaches upon and beclouds. Buyssens and Van der Waerden, in their zeal to defend the independence of thought against the monists, fall headlong into dualism. Another source of dualism with regard to the relationship between language and thought is the narrow conception of language which holds that drawing, mathematical symbols, gestures and the like do not form part of language. Because dualism is based on, or is given rise to by, these errors, restrictions and exaggerations, it cannot be an adequate solution to our problem, though those who hold this view help in calling our attention to the danger of identifying language and thought. To correct the extremities of both the monists and the dualists, there are those who stand on the mean

position. I make bold to call these the "symbiosists"⁴² and their view a "symbiotic view".

The Symbiotic View

Those with the symbiotic view about the interrelationship between language and thought are of the opinion that language and thought are different but not separate from each other. Each needs the other for its being and for its function. They are interdependent one on the other. There is, therefore, a symbiotic relationship between them. Those holding this view include such famous thinkers as Aristotle, St. Thomas Aquinas, Thomas Hobbes, George Berkeley, F. de Saussure, Heidegger, Wittgenstein, Fodor, Chomsky etc. I will discuss this view under seven subheadings.

i) The classical moderate view (Aristotle and Aquinas)

Aristotle recognises that language and thought bear some relationship to each other. Words, according to him, are "symbols of thought."⁴³ To underline the difference between thought and language he points out that although all men do not have the same speech sounds (the same language), "the mental experiences, which these directly symbolize, are the same for all".⁴⁴ The symbols (languages) are not the same for all people but the ideas (thoughts) can be the same. Let us note, however, that Aristotle is not saying that these ideas can exist or be formed without any symbols at all. He makes it clear in another work that the mind cannot have pure thought: "the soul never thinks without an image", rather the mind "thinks the forms in the images".⁴⁵ The soul perceives through the senses and forms

⁴² I am coining this term from the word "symbiosis" in the sense of interdependence.

⁴³ Aristotle, *On Interpretation*, 16a.

⁴⁴ *Ibid.*

⁴⁵ Aristotle, *On The Soul*, 431a-b.

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images, but it does not think particular things in their particularity, but thinks them in the universal forms like man, tree etc. The mind which is the intellectual part of the soul thinks the universals which are always the symbolic representations of the particulars. Language is understood as all forms of symbolic representation. It is a means of informing and getting informed. Because thinking is in the form of symbolic representation, in the form of abstract concepts, language is quite necessary for it. The fact that Aristotle denies the possibility of pure thought and at the same time holds that simple imagination is not thinking (for both man and brute can imagine, but only man can think),⁴⁶ implies that thinking is possible only by means of symbolic mediation between the thinker and what is being thought. Only that animal which possesses νοῦς (mind) is capable of thinking. Mesthene (1970) interprets Aristotle's term "νοῦς" as "logos, discourse, language"⁴⁷. He understands Aristotle's active intellect to be but language. Only man among all animals is capable of symbolic representation and, because of his faculty of language, man, and only man the "*homo loquens*", can perform intellectual work, can organise and judge.⁴⁸ Therefore, for Aristotle, thought is different from language but it functions through the mediation of language.

The important point to be noted in Aristotle's treatment of thought and representations is his formulation of the problem of the transition from sensual perception to abstract logical thought, a transition, as it were, from particular to universal. Any attempt to resolve this philosophical and psychological problem often goes back to the examination of the role of

⁴⁶*Ibid.*, 433a

⁴⁷ E. G. Mesthene, *How Language makes us Know. Some Views about the Nature of Intelligibility*. Netherlands: The Hague, 1970, pp. 10 - 11.

⁴⁸ Aristotle, *Politics*, 1253a.

language in thinking. Hence the close relationship between these two mental activities.

Aquinas toes the line of Aristotle in maintaining the inseparable relationship between language and thought. In perceiving language as the interior concept of the mind, he seems to identify language and thought. The reason for this is understandable when we are conscious of the fact that his treatment of the problem of language and thought is an attempt to establish the Second Person of the Trinity as the Word. Thus, his concern is that of substantiating the Word. He aims at proving the reality of the Word as something which exists on its own, and not a mere sound.

St. Thomas distinguishes three concepts of language and the fourth figurative one: language as the interior concept of the mind, language as the external vocal sound, language as the imagination of the vocal sound (inner conversation), and language as speech or talk given by someone (*parole, Rede*). Therefore, language is not just the external expression of thought. It is rather language which moves the intellect itself and enables it to think. That is to say that the intellectual work is done by means of language. Word belongs to the intellect and it is word (as intelligible species) which puts the intellect in act.⁴⁹ Man understands by means of word, says Aquinas. Thus, contrary to St. Augustine's position that language plays no role in the constitution of thought and in the activity which is called thinking, Aquinas recognises that thought functions by means of language. While St. Augustine holds that the human mind comes to know the universal essence through "divine illumination", St. Thomas says that the human mind on its own is capable of recognising the intelligible and essential aspect of

⁴⁹ St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologica*, First Part, Q. 43, Art. 1.

sense objects. St. Thomas, in line with Aristotle, does not accept the theory of innate ideas nor that of divine illumination. Man's active intellect is capable of discovering in individual objects the universal essence through the process of abstraction. The active intellect operates by means of language in this abstraction and the formation of universal concepts. Aquinas makes a statement that seems to treat thought as a kind of interior speech. He writes: "when the mind turns itself to the actual consideration of any habitual knowledge, then a person speaks to himself; for the concept of the mind is called the interior word."⁵⁰ The point in St. Thomas's treatment of the relationship between language and thought is that language plays a primary and an indispensable role in the internal constitution of thought, and only a secondary role in the external expression of such a thought. Thus, language is closely related to thought but is at the same time different from it.

ii) *The non-priority of thought to language (Hobbes and Berkeley)*

In his own contribution to the discussion on the relationship between language and thought, Hobbes takes time to underline the difference between language and thought but at the same time he shows that both are interdependent. He traces the problem back to the ancient Greeks who, he remarks, "have but one word, *λογος*, for both *speech* and *reason*". He notes that this is so "not that they thought there was no speech without reason, but no reasoning without speech".⁵¹ It is by means of language that "men register their thoughts, recall them when they are past, and also declare them one to another for mutual utility and conversation; without which there had been amongst men neither Commonwealth, nor society, nor contract, nor

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, Q. 107, Art. 1.

⁵¹ Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, chapter IV.

peace, no more than amongst lions, bears, and wolves."⁵² It is because men are endowed with the power of speech that they are capable of such intellectual activities as forming society, making contract etc., activities which non-rational animals (because they lack the faculty of language) cannot engage on. Man is rational because he is endowed with language. It is language that enables him to reason (*ratio*), to calculate. He defines reason as "reckoning (that is, adding and subtracting) of the consequences of general names agreed upon for the marking and signifying of our thoughts". He explains further that "I say marking them, when we reckon by ourselves; and signifying, when we demonstrate or approve our reckoning to other men".⁵³ One can understand the verb *to reason* as it is used by Hobbes to mean *to think*. Thus, Hobbes means that man thinks (reasons) through language and expresses to others the result of his thought through language as well. For Hobbes, the formation of thoughts is the first and natural purpose of language, while the expression of thought is only its secondary function. He negates the view that thought is inborn in man. Even if man is a rational animal, he does not actually reason from birth. Man comes to the age of reason when he comes to the age of speech. "Children", he writes, "are not endowed with reason at all, till they have attained the use of speech".⁵⁴ Therefore, thinking, properly understood as the intellectual activity of the mind, is, for Hobbes, not possible without language.

⁵²*Ibid.*, cf. also chapter XLVI.

⁵³*Ibid.*, chapter V

⁵⁴*Ibid.* See also Jean Piaget and Vygotsky in chapter three.

Berkeley⁵⁵ clearly rejects the expressionist view about language according to which language does nothing more than expressing or communicating the ideas in the mind of the speaker. He rejects the Locke's opinion that there are ideas in the mind of the speaker which determine the meaning of the speaker's words. He considers it a mistake for Locke to think that "there are certain abstract, determinate ideas that constitute the true and only immediate signification of each general name". Locke's theory of abstract ideas is borne out of misunderstanding for "there is no such thing as one precise and de-finite signification" of each general name which corresponds to the ideas in the mind of the speaker. Words are not labels of the ideas in the mind. It is from this misguided theory of abstract ideas in the mind which needs to be expressed, says Berkeley that language is taken to have no other end but that of "communicating our ideas". Other ends of language, according to Berkeley include "the raising of some passion, the exciting to or deterring from an action, the putting of the mind in some particular disposition". Rather than being simply the expression of ideas, language often creates ideas in the mind and awakens certain passions, feelings and dispositions for, writes Berkeley, "indeed, the words might have occasioned ideas . . .". Another use of language is that it is through it mainly that a person comes to gain from the intellectual fruits of others. Thus language is an effective means of gaining ideas, and not simply of expressing it. We learn a lot by mean of language, as we read in Berkeley: "words are of excellent use, in that by their means all that stock of knowledge which has been purchased by the joint labours of inquisitive men in all ages and nations may be drawn into the view and made the possession of one single person".

⁵⁵ All the references in this paragraph under George Berkeley come from the Introduction to his famous work, *The Principles of Human Knowledge*, (1710).

At the same time Berkeley calls our attention to the fact that language does a lot of disservice to our knowledge and thinking. He remarks that "most parts of knowledge have been strangely perplexed and darkened by the abuse of words and general ways of speech wherein they are delivered". Here the problem, I must say, is not with language but with *its abuse*. To say that language does not only serve as a means of expressing ideas but in most cases occasions them makes all the point in Berkeley's philosophy of language and thought. It is because language plays important role in the formation of our thought that it is very important to avoid the abuse of words in philosophy and in other sciences. When Berkeley writes of confining his thoughts to his own "ideas divested of words", I understand him as proposing a scientific inquiry free from the biases and misguided jargons in philosophy and other sciences. Ideas divested of words is not to be understood as thought without language. It is a call for each thinker to see things for himself and not to allow himself to be carried away by certain nonsensical and misleading jargons used by others. It is in the light of this interpretation that Berkeley calls for the clearing of the First Principles of Knowledge (the mind) "from the embarrass and delusion of words". Obscure and nonsensical jargons perplex and darken the human thought not in the sense of darkening or perplexing the ideas that are already there, but in the sense that such jargons lead to the formation of false ideas. Such jargons *misinform* our mind and lead us to error rather than informing our mind and leading us to knowledge. It is only where there can be information that there can also be misinformation. The human mind is informed and misinformed by means of language.